2.1 Classroom Habits for Success

Getting Started

Starting class at the University of Phoenix is a big event. You are starting a journey that could have a lasting impact on your life, but what should you do first. In the video below, veteran University of Phoenix faculty member, Brad Carroll, discusses some tips for getting started as well as best practices to support your learning and engagement in the online classroom.

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Figure 2.1.1: Habits for Success

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Transcript

Preparing for Success

As you start your journey at University of Phoenix, you might find the experience of online learning is different than you expected. You might face challenges you didn't expect or come across information with which you aren't familiar. It can be disorienting to take on such a new experience. Luckily, identifying and discussing ways to address those concerns is a focus of this week's learning. Before you get too far into this week's learning, take a moment to complete the Success Prep Inventory (SPI) to get a sense of your current level of readiness. This is just an inventory. There are no "right" or "wrong" answers. Think of the SPI as an opportunity to learn more about how you can be a better student.

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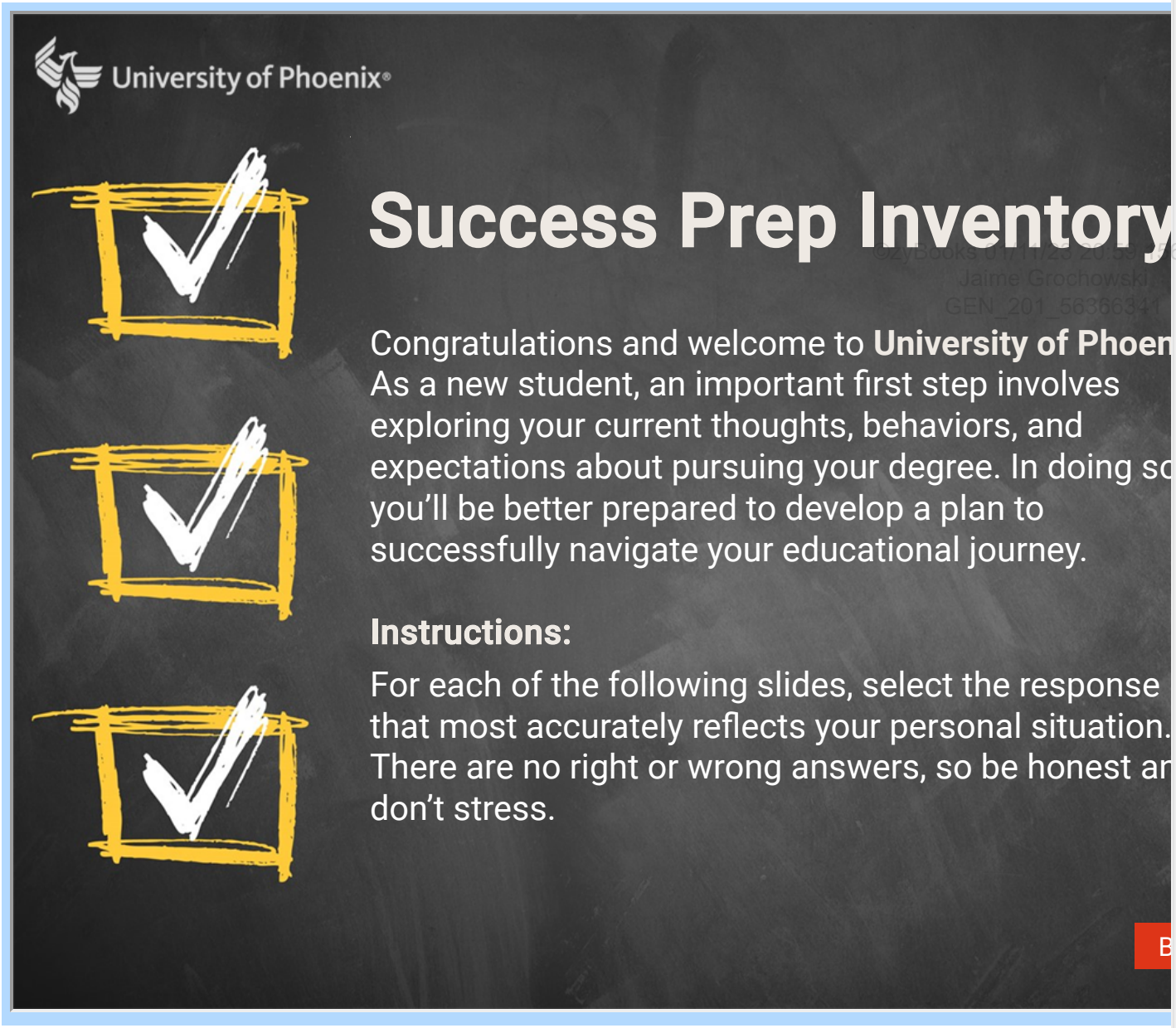
Figure 2.1.2: Success Prep Inventory



2.2 Benefits of Earning a College Degree

Professional Benefits

Many students at University of Phoenix pursue their college degree for professional reasons. Whether they're interested in changing careers, looking to enhance their skills, or working to start their own business, they all share the common goal of earning a degree. While each person benefits differently from earning a college degree, some of the most common professional benefits include:

- Career advancement opportunities
- Better and additional career options
- Specialized preparation or training
- Opportunities for a change in direction
- Increased financial earning potential

- Improved professional network
- Competitive edge over colleagues or other job applicants
- Enhanced knowledge base
- Exposure to experts in specific areas
- Higher job satisfaction
- Job security

Personal Benefits

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Earning a college degree also provides many personal benefits including:

- Expanding one's social circle
- Increasing one's confidence and self-worth
- Improving one's lifestyle
- Creating a sense of accomplishment
- Setting a positive example for friends and family
- Developing a more worldly understanding of physical, emotional, social, philosophical, and political factors

Other Benefits

Students also benefit both personally and professionally from the process that drives their learning. This process can greatly enhance:

- Interpersonal skills
- Lifelong-learning skills
- Communication skills
- Critical-thinking skills
- Problem-solving skills
- Technological skills
- Global-thinking skills
- Time-management skills
- Writing and math skills
- Leadership skills
- Intercultural skills

2.3 Motivation and Student Success

Student Motivation

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Whether you're a working professional, stay-at-home parent, or someone looking for a new opportunity in life, earning a college degree or certificate takes dedication, persistence, and most importantly, motivation. What motivates a person to embark on such a journey is unique. At the University of Phoenix, students are motivated by a variety of reasons, some of which include:

- Completing a program that was previously started but never completed
- Advancing in one's career
- Accomplishing a personal goal
- Learning a new set of skills

All students at the University of Phoenix are connected by a common goal: a motivation to learn. By gaining a better understanding of your personal motivations, you'll be in a better position to succeed at achieving your educational goals.

Figure 2.3.1: Cap & Gown Selfie

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Maybe the reality of graduation is not in sight yet. Or maybe it feels you are closing in on this goal. Whatever the case, to keep your motivation up, or just for fun, create your own **Cap & Gown Selfie**. Click on the link below and follow the steps to make your selfie. Keep it as the lock screen or wallpaper photo on your phone, or use it as your student profile picture—the choice is yours.

Cap & Gown Selfie

Introduction to Motivation

Understanding what drives you to earn your degree can be a critical factor in your success. In this section, you'll explore the topic of motivation, including some of the barriers you might encounter along the way.

Take a moment to watch as veteran faculty member Brad Carroll discusses the importance of motivation to supporting your personal, professional, and academic success.

Figure 2.3.2: Introduction to Motivation

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Transcript

Internal and External Motivation

While the benefits to earning a degree are a strong motivator for most students, there are other external and internal factors that influence each student's drive to succeed. If you're motivated by personal enjoyment or interest or fulfillment, your motivation is influenced by internal—or intrinsic—factors. By contrast, if you're motivated by outside recognition or financial reward, your motivation is influenced by external—or extrinsic—factors. Regardless of the type, motivation is instrumental in reaching your goals and achieving success.

Internal (Intrinsic) Motivation (Reeve, 2018)

- Internal motivation is a type of motivation that is influenced by an internal need for satisfaction, enjoyment, or personal growth.
- This type of motivation supports feelings of autonomy, competence, and relatedness.
- Examples of internal motivators include:
    - Interest
    - Mastery
    - Challenge
    - Exploration

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External (Extrinsic) Motivation (Reeve, 2018)

- External motivation is a type of motivation that results from external influences and consequences.
- This type of motivation exists as a form of "in order to" motivation (i.e., "Do this and you'll get that").
- Examples of external motivators include:
    - Recognition
    - Paychecks
    - Competition

- Achievement

General Examples of Internal and External Motivation

Internal Motivation	External Motivation
Participating in a sport because it is fun and you enjoy it.	Participating in a sport because you want to win a medal or trophy.
Spending time with friends because you enjoy their company.	Spending time at a networking function because you want to expand your job opportunities.
Taking on new responsibilities at your job because you want a new challenge.	Taking on new responsibilities at your job because you want your boss's recognition.
Studying hard because you find the subject interesting.	Studying hard because you want a good grade.
Earning a degree to increase opportunities to contribute at work or in the community.	Earning a degree to increase earning potential or job status.

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Maintaining Motivation

Online learning is ideal for adult learners who juggle various demands. While the flexibility of online learning makes higher education possible for some and appeals to many, such learning requires self-discipline and self-pacing. To maintain your motivation to complete your degree, here are some tips to ensure your success. More on each tip will be explored over the upcoming weeks in our class.

- **Set Goals**
  - Setting goals crystallizes priorities and allows better time management.
- **Generate a Backup Plan**
  - Life has a way of exposing people to unexpected events. Being prepared for technical problems, power outages, or childcare emergencies can decrease tension and anxiety and help you persist in your program.
- **Create a Support Network**
  - While the responsibility for completing your schoolwork rests on your shoulders, having a support system is vital for your well-being.
- **Reach Out to Instructors**
  - Your instructor is one of your best resources. They are rich in knowledge and always willing to answer questions or address concerns. Reaching out also allows you to establish a stronger rapport, which helps build trust and mutual understanding.

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- **Reach Out to Peers**
  - It feels good to connect with others who are on similar educational journeys. Whether it means connecting on a personal or academic level, you all have knowledge and experience to share with each other.
- **Join Message Boards for Students**
  - Networking with peers outside of the classroom environment may uncover new points of view and fresh opportunities.
- **Plug into Social Media Websites for Collaboration or Sharing**

- There are a variety of social media outlets that host official groups. Feel free to explore options out there for fresh perspectives!

PARTICIPATION ACTIVITY | 2.3.1: Motivation

1) Which of the following is an external motivator for enrolling in college?

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- A desire for knowledge
- A desire to get a higher paying job
- A desire to be a good role model for children
- Increased self-esteem from accomplishing a long-term goal

2) Esteban has been with the same employer for five years. Esteban enjoys his work, but he is unfulfilled and wants to offer all his talents to the company and its employees in a management role. Unfortunately, Esteban doesn't have a bachelor's degree, which is required to be considered for a management position. After discussing his feelings, his goals, and the steps needed to attain them with his family, he enrolls in a degree program that will allow him to work while also attending classes.

Esteban's motivation to attain his bachelor's degree is an example of which kind of motivation?

- Intrinsic motivation
- Extrinsic motivation
- Both intrinsic and extrinsic motivation
- None of the above

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3) Tyra is in the second year of her degree program in business. She studies tirelessly to earn top grades because

she enjoys the praise she receives from her peers and family members for being at the top of her class. Additionally, she is very curious about business topics and enjoys learning about all kinds of subject matter.

Tyra's motivation to study is an example of which kind of motivation?

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- Intrinsic motivation
- Extrinsic motivation
- Both intrinsic and extrinsic motivation
- None of the above

4) Jules was laid off from their job as a mid-level manager six months ago. After spending weeks looking for a new job in the same industry, they eventually accepted an entry-level position that would support their basic needs until they could find a better job.

Jules's motivation to work in an entry-level position is an example of which kind of motivation?

- Intrinsic motivation
- Extrinsic motivation
- Both intrinsic and extrinsic motivation
- None of the above

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Figure 2.3.3: Reflect on Your Learning

At the beginning of this section you were asked, "What influenced your decision to pursue your college degree?"

After learning more about motivation, reflect on your initial answer and provide a response to the following questions:

- Do you believe your decision was intrinsically or extrinsically motivated? Why?
- Now that you've started your program, what motivates you to be successful?
- Based on the tips for maintaining and managing your motivation, what steps will you take to support your continued motivation?

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2.4 The Importance of Growth Mindset and Grit

Grit and the Power of Believing

There are countless personal factors that can directly affect your ability to reach your goals. In the previous section, you learned about motivation and how intrinsic and extrinsic factors can motivate you. In this section, you'll explore two more factors that play an active part in attaining your goals—grit mindset and growth mindset.

In this short video, experienced GEN/201 faculty member Brad Carroll gives a brief introduction to the concepts of grit mindset and growth mindset.

Figure 2.4.1: Grit and the Power of Believing

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Transcript

Grit vs. Growth Mindset

Dr. Carol Dweck, a psychologist from Stanford University, introduced the term *mindset* after conducting extensive research on the power of people's beliefs. In this context, beliefs are defined as the thoughts a person has about themself (e.g., qualities, skills, abilities, and so forth) (Dweck, 2006). Your mindset is an important part of your personality, but the type of mindset you adopt can significantly affect how you live your life.

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There are two primary mindsets: fixed and growth (Dweck, 2006). A fixed mindset is based on the belief that one's qualities, skills, and abilities are immovable or set in stone. People with this mindset have a persistent need to prove themselves. They critically evaluate their performance as either good or bad and use an internal monologue to pass judgment on themselves (Dweck, 2006).

In contrast, a growth mindset is based on the belief that one's qualities are flexible and can be cultivated through effort. People with this mindset believe in changing qualities that can be developed through learning. They view setbacks as opportunities for growth and use their internal monologue to monitor and learn from different situations (Dweck, 2006).

As you develop your understanding of mindsets, you'll begin to recognize how beliefs can influence a person's thoughts and actions. For some people, the idea of shifting their mindset sounds impossible. Others might argue that by changing their mindset, they'll lose a part of themselves. On the contrary, opening yourself up to growth will help you become more yourself, not less (Dweck, 2006). A shift in mindset doesn't remove your old beliefs. Rather, it combines your old beliefs with new beliefs to provide you with a different way to think, feel, and act.

Do you believe your ability to be successful in school is fixed? Do you wonder why some students succeed while others fail?

The answers to these questions vary by student, but to a certain extent, each of us has control over our achievements and disappointments based on the mindset we embrace. When faced with any opportunity, we can choose to view it as one that is simply not achievable, or we can choose to view it as one that is not *yet* achievable. The power to choose is within your control. As you review these examples of fixed and growth mindsets, reflect on the mindset you embrace to view the world. Do you currently lean towards a fixed mindset or a growth mindset? Are you open to adjusting your mindset?

Fixed Mindset	Growth Mindset
I am not good at writing.	Writing poses a few challenges for me.
I will never finish my college coursework.	I am not happy with how I have been approaching my college coursework.
I am bad at math, and I don't care.	I have not prioritized math, but when I am ready, I have many resources to help me.
My communication skills aren't very good.	I have not yet learned to communicate as strongly as others.
Some people are naturally good at managing their time; I am not.	I would like to become adept at managing my time, but I have not yet employed an approach to do so.

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TEDTalks: Self-Improvement

Watch "TEDTalks: Carol Dweck – The Power of Believing That You Can Improve" from the University Library. As you watch the video, think about how you can apply the concepts presented in this video to your academic life.

Maintaining Growth Mindset

Maintaining and managing a growth mindset will support your success as a student and in just about every other aspect of your life. Embrace the notion that you can grow your abilities and talents by exerting additional effort. To encourage the development of such a mindset, there are several practices you can adopt:

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- View areas of deficiency as areas of opportunity.
- Seek feedback for growth rather than feedback for praise.
- Revisit, review, and adjust short-term and long-term goals.
- Learn from and be inspired by the successes and failures of others.
- Strive for brain plasticity rather than elasticity. Plasticity refers to the brain's ability to rewire and modify its connections while elasticity refers to the brain's ability to stretch but return to original form.

What Is Grit?

Grit refers to the continuous effort applied to achieve a goal. Angela Duckworth, the world's foremost leading psychologist and expert on grit, argues that passion and perseverance, the key ingredients to grit, will ensure personal success. Grit is not about intensity of effort; it is about consistency of effort, applied over time (Duckworth, 2020). For instance, while studying all night may seem to embody an intense approach to mastering material, it does not reflect the notion of grit. Instead, studying consistently over the span of many months better describes grit. The grit you choose to harness as a student will greatly impact your experience here at the University of Phoenix. How much grit are you willing to call upon to see your dreams become reality?

TEDTalks: Grit and Success

You have already taken the first steps toward your own academic and professional goals by enrolling in this course. Awareness of how we think about our successes and failures is essential to staying motivated and achieving those goals. Take a few minutes to watch "TEDTalks: Angela Lee Duckworth – The Key to Success? Grit" from the University Library. As you watch the video, think about how your current mindset could be helping or hindering you.

On the road to gaining such benefits, there may be obstacles unique to your journey. With planning, grit, and perseverance, however, such obstacles can be surmounted.

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Overcoming Obstacles

Common Roadblocks	Roadblock Bulldozers
Fear of failure	• Analyze prior failures and treat yourself kindly while setting yourself up for future success.

	• Establish a more personal connection with your instructor by personally reaching out weekly.
Technology	• Call UOPX Tech Support at 1-877-832-4867 or use the Live Chat feature. • Visit the Blackboard Ultra Resources page.
Lack of confidence in foundational skills	• Visit the Center for Writing Excellence and Center for Mathematics Excellence for resources.
Time management	• Review your schedule and determine how your time can be better spent, rather than wasted. • Prioritize and highlight urgent tasks.
Health concerns	• Don't be afraid to ask for help and notify your instructor. • Engage in appropriate eating, sleeping, and exercise behaviors.
Disabilities and accessibility needs	• Contact Accessibility and Disability Services to determine appropriate accommodations. • Inform your instructor of any accommodation needs.
Competing priorities	• Create a task list using a priority matrix. • Multitasking should be used for tasks that are not particularly difficult; as difficulty increases, choose to focus your attention on one task at a time.
Prior experiences	• Accept that success has not happened yet but is within reach. • Dwelling on negative thoughts drains emotional energy; instead, focus your energy on what you will do differently next time.
Negative self-view	• Remember to speak kindly to yourself and as if you were talking to your best friend. • Learn to distinguish between what you can control and what you cannot.
Lack of financial resources/options	• Visit the UOPX Scholarships and Financial Aid sites for options. • Reach out to a finance advisor to discuss your options.

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	• Understand the differences among payment options, including grants, scholarships, loans, tuition reimbursement, military benefits, and self-pay.

PARTICIPATION ACTIVITY 2.4.1: Grit and Growth Mindset

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1) Nijah has taken piano lessons all her life. While she considers herself to be a capable player, she believes her skills are limited. Recently, her pastor asked if she would be interested in performing regularly at the church. Despite feeling nervous about playing to a live audience, she accepted the invitation. At first, Nijah only played music she knew very well to minimize any mistakes she might make. After several performances, she became more comfortable and set a goal to start playing pieces that were more challenging. Eventually, she branched out even more by including other musicians to play with her.

Does Nijah's approach to playing the piano reflect a growth or fixed mindset?

- Fixed mindset
- Growth mindset
- Both fixed and growth mindsets
- None of the above

2) Darnell wants to apply for a management position at his present place of employment, but he constantly questions his abilities by asking himself, *"Do I have what it takes? Am I good enough? Will I be viewed as a failure? Will I be viewed as a winner? Will I face acceptance or rejection?"*

What mindset is reflected in Darnell's inner monologue?

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- Fixed mindset
- Growth mindset
- Both fixed and growth mindsets
- None of the above

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3) Maria has been working as a cashier for 8 years and has always had good performance reviews. Over the last 3 years, she has applied for management positions on multiple occasions but has been passed over. Recently, a co-worker told her about a new management position that just opened up and encouraged her to apply. Although her goals haven't changed, she's doesn't believe she'll ever have the skills or experience to be selected for the job, so she probably won't apply.

   Based on what you learned from the video, "Grit: The Power of Passion and Perseverance," what's the best way for Maria to build her grit?

   - There isn't a best known way.
   - Embrace a growth mindset.
   - Recognize failure is permanent despite effort.
   - Cultivate emotional intelligence.

4) Who, in the following examples, is demonstrating a growth mindset?

   - Mark decides to join his neighbor's book club so he can meet new people and explore books he may not have read on his own.

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- Anna has struggled with writing in the past, so she visits the Center for Writing Excellence to prepare for her upcoming English class.
- Augustine started listening to audio books on strategies for growing small businesses during his commute.
- All of the above

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Figure 2.4.2: Reflect on Your Learning

After learning about fixed and growth mindsets, consider the following questions:

- Which mindset best represents you at this stage in your life? Why?
- How do you think your mindset affects your educational and professional experiences?

2.5 Paying for College

Responsible Borrowing

Many college students will use federal student loans to pay tuition and college expenses. In general, federal loans go into repayment six months after your last date of attendance. Yet, planning for repayment should start when you first borrow. A general guideline is that your future standard monthly payment will be about $10 for every $1,000 you borrow. We suggest borrowing only what you need to keep that future payment more manageable. If you borrow additional funds of $3,000 per year, that could be another $12,000 borrowed—or an extra $120 a month.

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What non-loan options may be available to you? Can you find money in your budget to pay a portion of tuition? Have you applied for any scholarships? Does your employer offer tuition reimbursement? Have you researched prior learning assessment and national testing programs? Check out the "Paying for School" page for information on different options to pay for school. Use the Scholarship Search to learn more about scholarships and to find some to apply for.

Know Your Repayment Options

Your loans may not be in repayment yet, but that doesn't mean you should not pay attention to them. Besides knowing how much you owe now and in the future, it's also important to know what your monthly payment might be so you can plan for it.

Federal student loans have several repayment plans that will determine your monthly payment and how long the repayment term is. Students typically start out in the Standard plan which is a fixed payment amount each month for up to a 10-year term. The Graduated plan also has a 10-year term, but payments start out lower and increase every 2–3 years. The extended plan will have a lower payment due to a term of up to 25 years. And there are also income-driven plans, such as the Income-Based Repayment Plan, Pay As You Earn Repayment Plan, and Revised Pay As You Earn Repayment Plan. These plans base your payment on income and family size; as such you will provide income information each year.

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These plans can lower your monthly payment to make it more affordable, but keep in mind that the longer you repay, the higher the total interest cost. Read Breaking Down The Student Loan Repayment Options to learn more. And you can estimate your future monthly payment under the different plans with Federal Student Aid's Loan Simulator. You can find information about your current federal student loans on studentaid.gov.

Watch the following video to learn more about responsible borrowing:

Figure 2.5.1: Responsible Borrowing

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Learn More About Money: iGrad

When planning for how to pay for college and repay student loans, managing your money is an important skill. To help you further develop this skill, we've partnered with iGrad to make this money management site available to all students through their Account. Check out these helpful tutorials to get started:

- Borrowing Smart and Preparing for Higher Education

- Creating a Budget (and Sticking to It)
- Finding Scholarships to Help Pay for School
- Creating a Financial Plan for Your Priorities and Goals

PARTICIPATION ACTIVITY | 2.5.1: Responsible Borrowing

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1) Which of the following repayment plans is NOT available with federal student loans?

- Standard plan
- Graduated plan
- Inactive plan
- Pay as You Earn plan

2) With this type of federal loan, you are responsible for the interest that accrues as soon as the loan is disbursed.

- Unsubsidized loan
- Subsidized loan
- Grant
- Scholarship

3) This type of federal financial aid does not have to be paid back.

- Unsubsidized loan
- Subsidized loan
- Grant

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Figure 2.5.2: Reflect on Your Learning

While financial aid is one way to pay for your education, some other options include:

- Tuition reimbursement
- Military benefits
- Paying out-of-pocket
- Scholarships

As you know, unexpected events can easily disrupt your life. It's important to have a back-up plan for paying for your education, in case something unexpected happens. Should you be faced with such a challenge, what's your back-up plan? If you don't have a plan in place yet, what steps can you take to prepare for such an event?

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*****YOU HAVE NOW COMPLETED ALL OF THE READINGS FOR WEEK 1*****

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